

ApprovalFlow

# User Manual

For people who submit requests and people who approve them

This manual explains how to sign in, submit a request and follow its progress, and how to review and decide on requests that are sent to you for approval. Administrators have a separate manual.

# Contents

|                                  |    |
|----------------------------------|----|
| 1. How the system works          | 3  |
| 2. Signing in and your account   | 4  |
| 3. Submitting a request          | 7  |
| 4. Following your requests       | 9  |
| 5. Approving requests            | 11 |
| 6. Reference and troubleshooting | 15 |

## CHAPTER 1

# How the system works

ApprovalFlow moves a request through a fixed series of approval steps. Each form has its own chain of approvers, set up by your administrator.

1. A **submitter** fills in a form and submits it. The request gets a number such as **REQ-000123**.
2. The approver for **Step 1** receives an email with the request's details and **Approve**, **Send back for changes** and **Reject** buttons. They review the request and decide.
3. If they approve, the request moves to the next step and that approver is emailed. This repeats until the last step.
4. If something only needs fixing, the approver **sends it back**. The submitter edits the request and resubmits it, and it goes straight back to that same approver. Steps already approved stay approved.
5. When the final approver approves, the request is **Approved**. A PDF of the complete record is created and archived, and the submitter is emailed.
6. If **any** approver rejects, the workflow stops immediately. The request is **Rejected**, which is final. The submitter is emailed the reason, and a PDF marked REJECTED is archived.

## Your role decides what you see

| Role          | What you can do                                                                                          |
|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Submitter     | Submit forms. See <b>only your own</b> requests, their progress, the outcome and the PDF.                |
| Approver      | Decide on the steps assigned to you. See the submission and the sections completed by earlier approvers. |
| Administrator | Configure forms and users and oversee all requests (see the Administrator Manual).                       |

One person can hold more than one role. If you do, your home page shows a section for each.

## CHAPTER 2

# Signing in and your account

Open the address your organisation gave you (for example **https://acme.approvals.example.com**). You do not need to be given an account: you create it yourself the first time you sign in.

### NOTE

Your organisation has **its own address**, and the sign-in page shows its name and logo so you can tell you are in the right place. If you also use this system for another organisation, that is a separate address and a separate account, with its own password key - the same email address at a different address is a different account.

## First time: create your 6-digit password key

1. On the **Sign in** page enter your **work email** and choose **Continue**.
2. A **6-digit verification code** is emailed to that address. It proves the address is yours, and expires after **10 minutes**.
3. On the **Create your password key** page enter the code, your **full name**, and a **6-digit password key** of your own choice, twice.
4. Choose **Create key and sign in**. You are signed in straight away.
  - The key is **digits only, exactly six**. Obvious keys are refused: the same digit repeated (111111), simple sequences (123456, 654321) and repeated patterns (121212, 123123).
  - No email? Check your junk folder. To get a new code, choose **change**, enter your email again and choose **Continue** - a new code can be sent after one minute.
  - A code allows **5 attempts**. After that, request a new one.
  - New accounts can submit requests. If you need to **approve** requests, ask an administrator to give you the Approver role after you have signed in once.

### NOTE

Your organisation may restrict sign-up to its own email domains. If you see "Only your organisation's email addresses can be used here", use your work address.

## Signing in afterwards

Enter your email, choose **Continue**, then type your 6-digit password key and choose **Sign in**.

## Help: this manual in the app

## Light or dark colours

The small icon next to **Help** in the top bar - also at the top of the sign-in page - switches the colours. Each click moves to the next choice:

| Icon            | Colours                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Screen (System) | Follow the setting of your computer or phone: light by day or dark, as you have chosen there. This is where everyone starts. |
| Sun (Light)     | Always light, whatever your computer is set to.                                                                              |
| Moon (Dark)     | Always dark: black backgrounds with light text and yellow highlights - easier on the eyes in a dim room.                     |

Your choice is remembered on that computer or phone, in that browser, and is not part of your account: set it again on another device if you like. It changes nothing but the colours.

Once you are signed in, choose **Help** in the top-right corner, next to your name, then **User Manual** (this manual) or **How a request works (workflow)** - a two-page sheet: the whole approval process as a diagram, then each step explained with who does it and which emails go out. It opens in a new tab, in your browser's own PDF viewer, where you can read, search, save or print it. The manuals can only be opened by people who are signed in; a link to one stops working after a few minutes, so always open it again from **Help** rather than from a saved address.

## Changing your password key

Click **your name** in the top-right corner, enter your current key and the new one twice, and choose **Change key**. Your other devices are signed out.

## Approval emails: each one, or a morning summary

Approvers can choose how they are emailed about requests waiting for them. Click **your name** in the top-right corner; under **Approval emails** choose:

| Choice                                    | What you get                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Email me about each request as it arrives | The usual: an <b>Approval needed</b> email for each request, plus resubmitted and reminder emails. This is where everyone starts.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Send me one summary each morning instead  | One email, <b>Monday to Friday at 7:00 AM</b> , listing everything waiting for you - request, form, requester, step, how long it has waited, and <b>OVERDUE</b> where it applies - with a link to each and an <b>Open my approvals</b> button. Nothing is sent on a morning when nothing is waiting. You get no separate approval, resubmitted, reassigned or reminder emails. |

The change takes effect at once. Whichever you choose, everything waiting is always on your home page, and if an administrator presses **Send reminder** for one of your requests, that reminder still reaches you straight away.

## Forgotten your password key

1. On the **Sign in** page enter your email and choose **Continue**.
2. Under the key box choose **Forgot your key?** A 6-digit verification code is emailed to you (valid for 10 minutes, 5 attempts).

3. Enter the code and your **new 6-digit key** twice, then choose **Save new key and sign in**.

Your old key stops working, your other devices are signed out, and a locked account is unlocked. Your requests, approvals and roles are untouched. If you can no longer read that mailbox, ask an administrator to reset your key instead; you will then create a new one the next time you sign in.

## Locked out

After **5 incorrect keys** the account is locked for **15 minutes**. During that time even the correct key is refused. Wait and try again - or use **Forgot your key?**, which also removes the lock.

### TIP

You stay signed in when you reload the page or open a link in a new tab. Choose **Sign out** (top right) when you finish on a shared computer.

## CHAPTER 3

# Submitting a request

## Start a new request

1. On your home page, under **Start a new request**, click the form you need. The page opens straight on its fields.
2. Fill in the fields. Fields marked with a red asterisk (\*) are required.
3. Some forms ask you to choose **who approves it first**, in the **Send to** box at the bottom of the form - for example a school, shown with the secretary's name beside it. You must pick one before submitting. That person will be asked to approve first, so check the details before you continue. You cannot choose yourself.
4. Choose **Submit for approval**. That person is emailed a link straight away.

If something is missing or not valid, nothing is submitted: the affected fields are highlighted with a message such as "Amount must be a number" and a banner asks you to fix them. Correct them and submit again.

| Field type        | What to enter                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Text / long text  | Free text. Long text keeps your line breaks.                                                                                                     |
| Number / currency | Digits only. Currency is stored with two decimal places. The form may set a minimum or maximum.                                                  |
| Date              | Pick from the calendar.                                                                                                                          |
| Choice            | Select one option from the list.                                                                                                                 |
| Tick box          | Tick for Yes. A required tick box must be ticked.                                                                                                |
| Lookup            | Choose from the list (long lists let you type to search). Boxes marked <b>auto-filled</b> next to it fill in by themselves and cannot be edited. |
| Email             | A valid email address.                                                                                                                           |
| Signature         | Sign in the box with your finger, a stylus or the mouse. <b>Undo</b> removes the last stroke and <b>Clear</b> starts again.                      |

## After you submit

- You see the request page with a green confirmation and the message **"Step 1 of N, waiting on <name>"**.
- You receive an email **"We received your ... request"** with a link to track it.
- The first approver is emailed at the same moment.

**IMPORTANT**

You can change a submitted request only when an approver sends it back to you for changes (see below). You cannot withdraw it yourself: if it was sent by mistake, ask an administrator to cancel it and submit a new one.



## CHAPTER 4

# Following your requests

## My submissions

Your home page lists everything you have submitted, newest first, with anything sent back to you at the top. Use the buttons **All** / **Needs my changes** / **In progress** / **Approved** / **Rejected** to filter. Each row shows:

- The request number (click it to open the request), form name and submission date.
- A row of coloured bars, one per approval step: **green** = approved, **amber** = waiting now, **purple** = sent back to you, **red** = rejected here, **grey** = not reached yet.
- In words: "**Step 2 of 4 (Finance), waiting on Frank Finance for 3 days**", or the outcome.
- For a request sent back to you: who sent it back, what they asked for, and a **Make the changes** link.
- For rejected requests, the **rejection reason** and the step where it happened.
- A **Final PDF** or **Archived PDF** link once the PDF exists.

## The request page

The request page shows a banner with the current situation, the **Progress** tracker and **Your submission** exactly as you sent it (read-only).

The **Progress** tracker starts with when you submitted, then lists every step: who decided and when, or - for the step it is waiting on now - who has it, **since when and for how long**. Steps that sent it back to you show a small **Sent back by ...** line; click it to see what was asked and what you changed.

## If your request is sent back for changes

An approver can send your request back when something needs fixing - a missing detail, a wrong amount, a better quote. It is not rejected: nothing is lost, and steps already approved stay approved.

1. You receive an email "**Changes needed: your ... request**" with what the approver asked for. The request is marked **Sent back** at the top of **My submissions**, and the request page shows the same message in a purple banner.
2. Choose **Make the changes** (in the email, the list or the banner). The form opens with your answers filled in and the approver's request above it.
3. Change what is needed. A drawn **signature** is not carried over: sign again. You can add a **note** for the approver, for example what you changed.
4. Choose **Resubmit to <approver>**. The request goes straight back to the approver who sent it back, who is emailed a list of exactly what you changed.

The same approver can send it back again if needed. Each round is kept in the request's history and in its final PDF.

Whether you can see the comments and fields that approvers filled in depends on how your administrator set up the form. The decision, the approver's name and the date are always visible, and so is a rejection reason.

## If your request is rejected

- You receive an email with the **reason**, the **step**, the **approver** and the **date**.
- The request page shows the same details in a red banner.
- Rejection is **final**. The request cannot be reopened, edited or resumed, by anyone.
- To try again, choose **start a new request using these details**. A new form opens with your previous answers filled in; review them, change what is needed and submit. It is a completely new request with a new number and goes through every step again.
- Choose **Download archived PDF** for the full record of the rejected request.

## Downloading the PDF

When a request is Approved or Rejected, a PDF is produced within a minute or so. It contains your submission, every completed approver section with name, decision, comments, the approver's **signature** and time, and an audit summary. Each page shows your organisation's name and logo at the top, with a green **APPROVED** or red **REJECTED** badge. If the button says the PDF is being prepared, refresh the page shortly.

## Emails you will receive

| Email                              | When                                                                                                 |
|------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| We received your ... request       | Immediately after you submit.                                                                        |
| Changes needed: your ... request   | When an approver sends it back to you. Includes what to change and a <b>Make the changes</b> button. |
| Your ... request is fully approved | When the final approver approves.                                                                    |
| Your ... request was rejected      | When any approver rejects. Includes reason, step, approver and date.                                 |
| Your ... request was cancelled     | When an administrator cancels it. Includes their reason.                                             |

You are not emailed at each intermediate approval; open **My submissions** to see the current step at any time.

## CHAPTER 5

# Approving requests

## The approval email

When a request reaches your step you receive **"Approval needed: <form> <number>"**. The email lists the **request details** (what was submitted, up to 12 fields) so you can see what it is about straight away, followed by three buttons:

| Button                | What happens                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Approve               | Opens the request with your decision at the top, ready for your signature. Check the details underneath and choose <b>Approve</b> to confirm. |
| Send back for changes | Opens the request ready for you to say what needs to change.                                                                                  |
| Reject                | Opens the request with the rejection box ready for your reason.                                                                               |

Nothing is decided by the button in the email alone: you always confirm on the page. **Open the full request** under the buttons opens the page in its usual order. Your organisation may have turned the details off in emails; the buttons are always there.

- You must **sign in**. If you are not signed in, you are taken to the sign-in page and then straight to the request.
- The link is **personal**: it only works for your account. Forwarding it to a colleague does not let them act - ask an administrator to reassign the step or add a delegate instead.
- The link expires after **14 days**. After that, sign in normally and use your inbox (below), or ask an administrator to send a reminder, which contains a fresh link.
- A newer email for the same step replaces the older link.

## Your inbox: "Waiting for my approval"

Your home page lists every request currently waiting for you, oldest first, with the form, submitter, step and how long it has waited. An **Overdue** badge appears once it has passed the reminder period. You can open a request from here without the email.

## Approving several at once

When two or more requests are waiting, each row has a tick box, with **Select all** at the top of the list.

1. Tick the requests you want to approve and choose **Approve selected**.
2. A panel lists them, each with its first few details (for example the item and the amount). Check each one. **Remove** takes one out of the batch; to look closer, open its request number instead.
3. Comments are optional. **Comment for all of them** is saved on every request in the batch. To say something about one request only, choose **Add a comment for this request** under it: that request gets the shared comment followed by its own. Then **sign** once.

4. Choose **Approve N requests**. Each is approved exactly as if you had done it on its own page: the next approver is emailed, or, on the last step, the request is fully approved and its PDF made.
  - A result list shows each one: moved on to the next step, fully approved, or **not approved** with the reason (for example, somebody else decided it a moment ago). The others are not affected.
  - Only **approving** works in a batch. To send back or reject, open the request: those need their own reason.
  - Where approving means **choosing who approves next**, the panel shows a **Send to** box under that request - choose for each one (they can go to different people). After choosing for one, **Send the other ... to <name> too** fills in the rest in one click. **Approve** asks for any that are still missing.
  - Up to 50 at a time. Your one signature is saved with each approval and printed in each PDF.

## The approval page

| Section               | Contents                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Original submission   | Everything the submitter entered. <b>Read-only</b> .                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Previous approvals    | Each earlier step: approver, decision, date, their comments, their <b>signature</b> and any documents they attached (and, on older requests, any fields they completed). <b>Read-only</b> . Not shown on Step 1. You never see later steps.                                                                               |
| Sent back for changes | Earlier rounds in which this request was sent back: what was asked, when it came back and what the submitter changed. Only shown when there are any.                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Your section          | Three choices at the top - <b>Approve</b> , <b>Send back for changes</b> and <b>Reject</b> - and under them what that choice needs: for Approve a <b>Comments</b> box, <b>Attach documents</b> , the <b>Your signature</b> box and the <b>Send to</b> box when you choose the next approver. Highlighted with an outline. |

When a request comes back to you after you sent it back, a purple box at the top shows **exactly what the submitter changed** (old value crossed out, new value beside it) and their note.

## To approve

1. Read the submission and add comments if you wish. The system records your account, the time and your IP address with your decision.
2. Attach any documents that support your decision under **Attach documents** (see below). This is optional.
3. **Sign** in the **Your signature** box with your finger, a stylus or the mouse. Every step needs a signature to approve; **Undo** removes the last stroke and **Clear** starts again. If you choose Approve without signing, the box turns red with **Sign to approve**.
4. If a **Send to** box appears next to **Approve**, choose who approves the next step from its list - their details fill in beside it. You must pick someone before approving; you cannot choose yourself or the person who submitted the request. Rejecting needs no choice.
5. Choose **Approve**. If you chose who is next, they are emailed a link straight away.

A green message confirms the result: either the request has moved to the next step, or - if yours was the last step - it is fully approved and the submitter has been notified.

Your signature is kept with your decision. It is shown to the approvers of later steps and to administrators, and it is printed in the PDF of the request, which the submitter can also download.

## Attaching documents

Every step has **Attach documents** in your section. Choose **Choose Files** and pick one or more files.

- Allowed: PDF, Word, Excel, PowerPoint, text files and images, up to **10 MB** each and **10 files** per step.
- Until you decide, you can **Remove** a file you attached. Once you approve or reject, the files are part of the record and cannot be changed.
- Only the approvers of this request (from your step onwards) and administrators can open them. The submitter never sees them, and they are not listed in the PDF.

## To send back for changes

Use this when the request is basically right but something needs fixing. Unlike rejecting, it is not final.

1. Choose **Send back for changes**. No signature is needed.
2. In **What needs to change?** say what the submitter should do. This is mandatory and is emailed to them word for word.
3. Choose **Send back to <submitter>**.

The request leaves your **Waiting for my approval** list and your link stops working. When the submitter resubmits, it comes back to you with a new email ("**Resubmitted for approval**") listing what they changed, and you decide again. Earlier steps keep their approvals.

## To reject

1. Choose **Reject**. A red box opens. Rejecting does not need a signature.
2. Enter the **reason for rejection**. This is mandatory and is sent to the submitter word for word, so write it for them.
3. Choose **Confirm rejection**.

### IMPORTANT

Rejection is final and cannot be undone. The workflow stops, no later approver is contacted, the submitter and the administrator are notified, and a REJECTED PDF is archived. If the request only needs fixing, send it back instead.

## After the request is closed

Once a request you approved (or rejected) is finished, its approval page shows **Download PDF**: the complete record, the same one the submitter gets. Only the people who had a step in that request can download it, and each download is recorded.

## After you decide

Your section becomes **read-only** for everyone, including you, and so do your signature and any documents you attached. Opening the same email link again shows your recorded decision. A step can be decided only once: if you open the request in two tabs, or a delegate has already acted, the second attempt shows "This step has already been completed".

## Reminders, reassignment and delegates

- If the form has reminder rules, you receive "**Reminder: approval needed**" emails after the configured number of days. Each contains a fresh link. (Not if you chose the morning summary: it reminds you every weekday instead.)
- If a step waits too long, a manager or the administrators may receive an **escalation** notice. Nothing changes for you; the step is still yours.
- An administrator can **reassign** your step to someone else (your link then stops working) or add a **delegate** who can act as well as you. Whoever decides first is recorded.
- Going on leave? Ask an administrator to add a delegate or reassign your open steps.

## CHAPTER 6

# Reference and troubleshooting

## Request statuses

| Status      | Meaning                                                                                                                |
|-------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| In progress | Waiting for the approver of the current step - or, when marked <b>Sent back</b> , waiting for the submitter's changes. |
| Approved    | Every step approved. Final. PDF available.                                                                             |
| Rejected    | Rejected at one step. Final. Reason shown; PDF available.                                                              |
| Cancelled   | Stopped by an administrator before completion. Final.                                                                  |

## Step statuses

| Status              | Meaning                                                                                                |
|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Waiting             | Earlier steps are not finished yet.                                                                    |
| Active              | Waiting for this approver now.                                                                         |
| Sent back           | This approver sent the request back for changes. It becomes Active again when the submitter resubmits. |
| Approved / Rejected | Decided. The section is locked.                                                                        |
| Not reached         | An earlier step rejected the request, so this step never started.                                      |
| Cancelled           | The request was cancelled before this step was decided.                                                |

## Common messages

| Message                                        | What to do                                                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Incorrect email or password key                | Check your email address and key. After 5 wrong attempts the account locks for 15 minutes. Forgotten the key? Use <b>Forgot your key?</b> on the sign-in page. |
| That code is not right / This code has expired | Use the code from the <b>latest</b> email. After 5 wrong attempts or 10 minutes, go back and continue again to get a new code.                                 |
| This account already has a password key        | You are already set up: sign in with your key, or use <b>Forgot your key?</b>                                                                                  |

| Message                                                             | What to do                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| This link can't be used                                             | The approval link has expired, was replaced by a newer one, the step was reassigned, or you are signed in as a different person. Check <b>Waiting for my approval</b> , or ask an administrator for a reminder. |
| This approval does not exist or is not assigned to you              | The step belongs to someone else. Make sure you are signed in with the right account.                                                                                                                           |
| Sign to approve                                                     | Draw your signature in the <b>Your signature</b> box, then choose <b>Approve</b> again.                                                                                                                         |
| Say what needs to change                                            | Sending back needs a message for the submitter. Type it in <b>What needs to change?</b>                                                                                                                         |
| This request has not been sent back to you, so it cannot be changed | It was already resubmitted (perhaps in another tab), or an administrator cancelled it. Open the request to see where it is.                                                                                     |
| This step has already been completed                                | It was decided already (by you in another tab, or by a delegate). Refresh to see the result.                                                                                                                    |
| This request is rejected / cancelled and can no longer be changed   | The request closed while you had it open. No action is needed.                                                                                                                                                  |
| Request not found                                                   | The request is not yours, or the number is wrong. Submitters can open only their own requests.                                                                                                                  |
| The PDF has not been generated yet                                  | Wait a minute and try again.                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Too many attempts. Please wait a minute.                            | Sign-in attempts are rate-limited. Wait one minute.                                                                                                                                                             |
| A new version of ApprovalFlow is available                          | The system was updated while your page was open. Choose <b>Reload</b> (anything you have typed on this page is lost), or carry on: the next page you open is loaded in the new version by itself.               |

## Good practice

- Never share your password key or verification codes, and do not forward approval links. Every decision is recorded against your account with the time and IP address.
- Write rejection reasons, send-back messages and comments carefully: they become part of the permanent PDF record.
- Prefer **Send back for changes** over rejecting when a request can be fixed: the submitter does not have to start again.
- Decide promptly. Waiting requests are visible to administrators as overdue.